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5 Bizarrely Brilliant Irish Inventions That Made the World a Better Place



By Brian Keane — July 9, 2026 4 Mins Read



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Irish inventions have changed the world in more ways than you might realise, from life-saving medical breakthroughs to some of our favourite everyday treats.



Our little island has produced some famous exports, recognised all over the world. But beyond Guinness, great literature and breathtaking scenery, what has the land of saints and scholars

contributed to our everyday lives?

Here are five Irish inventions that changed the world – or at the very least, made it a little tastier.

5. Pulse of genius – *the invention that brought the hospital to you*



You won't find this **Irish invention** in a souvenir shop, but you will find it in airports, GAA grounds, community centres, as close as possible to places where people may suddenly remember they've left the immersion on.

Developed in Belfast during the 1960s by cardiologist Frank Pantridge and colleague John Geddes, the portable coronary care unit revolutionised emergency medicine. At a time when many patients couldn't receive life-saving treatment quickly enough, Pantridge got to the heart of the problem by bringing the hospital to them.

Today, automated external defibrillators (AEDs) are a familiar sight in public places across the world, quietly saving lives every day.

So, the next time you find yourself getting a little overly fibrillated, remember: Ireland's got you covered. You'll be grand.

4. Escape strategy – *the invention that gave pilots a second chance*



Credit: geograph.ie

If Hollywood has taught us anything, it's that if you're sitting in the passenger seat of **James Bond's Aston Martin**, you'd better be good company.

The ejector seat was developed by another Martin, James Martin of Crossgar, County Down. Following the death of his business partner, test pilot Valentine Baker, in a 1942 aircraft crash, Martin became determined to give future pilots a fighting chance of escaping doomed aircraft.

His company, Martin-Baker, estimates its ejector seats have since saved more than 7,700 lives around the world. James Bond may have made ejector seats famous, but James Martin made them possible.

3. Notions of taste – *more taste than your average potato*



Credit: Flickr / Lou Stejskal

Imagine a time when all crisps just tasted like... potatoes. Well, before Joe 'Spud' Murphy came along in 1954, that was all the choice the world had.

Working for **Tayto**, Murphy developed the world's first commercially successful flavoured potato crisps, introducing Cheese & Onion before following it up with Salt & Vinegar.



The idea proved so popular that crisp manufacturers around the world licensed the flavouring technology, forever changing the humble packet of crisps.

Inventing the world's first flavoured crisp was pretty impressive. It makes perfect sense that Tayto are still the best crisps around. This is one of the **Irish inventions everybody gets joy out of, but nobody credits.**

2. Getting a grip – *taking the bumps out of everyday life*



Credit: commons.wikimedia.org

Sometimes, solving your child's problems can change the world. When John Boyd Dunlop watched his young son being jolted around Belfast on a solid-tyred tricycle, he decided there had to be a better way.

In 1888, he developed the first practical pneumatic tyre, replacing solid rubber with air-filled tyres and transforming cycling before paving the way for modern motoring.

Today, every family car, Tour de France bicycle and Formula One racing car owes something to that simple idea. Every now and then, your kids are onto something.

1. Cream of the crop – *the invention that made Christmas a little merrier*

That was intense. How about we wind down with a drink? In 1974, a team working for Gilbeys of Ireland set itself an unusual challenge: combine two of Ireland's finest exports—Irish whiskey and fresh dairy cream—into one drink.

The result was Baileys Irish Cream, the world's first commercially successful cream liqueur. Solving the challenge of keeping whiskey and cream happily mixed together created a drink that's now enjoyed in more than 150 countries, whether **poured over ice, stirred into coffee or drizzled over dessert.**

Not every Irish invention has to save lives or change transport. Some simply make life a little sweeter.

So, whether it's a tasty snack, a smooth drive, saving a life or simply being fired out of a fighter jet, Ireland has you covered. Fair play to us altogether.

SHARE.





Brian Keane

Brian Keane is an Irish writer and architect from County Kilkenny. After spending 13 years living in Dublin, he moved to Pembroke in 2013, about as close to Ireland as you can be without actually living there. Brian firmly believes that some of the best adventures start on your doorstep. He loves rediscovering Ireland through both a tourist's eyes and the eyes of someone coming home, regularly returning to visit friends and family or explore the country by bicycle. A keen cyclist, runner and swimmer with an appetite to match, Brian is always on the lookout for a good mountain pass, a quiet beach for a dip, a proper chicken fillet roll, a good pint of Guinness and the general craic. For the past 15 years, he has written about his adventures in cycling and triathlon, often in an attempt to learn from his mistakes. He is currently writing a book about cycling around Wales for two weeks, a summer holiday idea he is still trying to explain.

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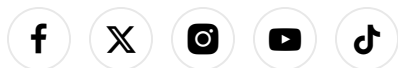


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